Students Studying in The United States

# ECONOMIC HARDSHIP AND SPECIAL STUDENT RELIEF (SSR)

F-1 and J-1 students who experience economic hardship after they begin their program of study at Northeastern may be eligible to apply for off campus work authorization.

## USCIS' NEW PHOTO POLICY AND SCHEDULING OF BIOMETRICS APPOINTMENTS

USCIS may issue you an "Appointment Scheduling Notice" to attend a biometrics appointment. Please review the guidance below to understand how this

may impact you.

USCIS Policy Changes – Updated January 30, 2026 (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/usc

# SEVERE ECONOMIC HARDSHIP EMPLOYMENT FOR F-1 STUDENTS

An F-1 student may apply to U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) for off-campus employment if they are experiencing economic hardship due to unexpected circumstances outside of their control. These circumstances may include but are not limited to:

- Loss of financial aid or on-campus employment
- Substantial changes in exchange rate or value of currency on which the student depends
- Inordinate increases in tuition and/or living expenses
- Unexpected changes in the main source of financial support
- Medical bills

As part of their application students must submit an I-20 with the appropriate recommendation from a Designated School Official (DSO) in OGS, and should be prepared to document the circumstances of their economic hardship, how they were unexpected and outside of their control, and present evidence to support these claims.

Severe Economic Hardship employment authorization is granted in one year intervals and is limited to 20 hours per week while school is in session. During official school breaks/vacations, employment may exceed 20 hours per week.

**Eligibility**

To apply for employment authorization due to severe economic hardship, USCIS has established the following eligibility requirements:

- Must have maintained lawful F-1 status for at least one academic year (2 semesters/3 quarters)
- Must be in good academic standing and maintain a full-time course load with appropriate on-ground presence
- Demonstrate that off-campus employment will not negatively impact your studies.
- Demonstrate that on-campus employment is not available/sufficient to avoid experiencing economic hardship.
- Demonstrate that off-campus employment is necessary to avoid economic hardship due to unexpected circumstances outside of your control

**Application**

If you believe you meet these eligibility requirements and wish to request an I-20 with the appropriate recommendation in order to submit an application to USCIS, or have additional questions about this process, please contact OGS) by calling +1-617-373-2310 or visiting the front desk at 354 Richards Hall in Boston.

You can find a more detailed explanation of the application process by accessing this knowledge article (https://northeastern.service-now.com/kb_view.do?sysparm_article=KB000022536).

# USCIS REVIEW OF PUBLICLY AVAILABLE SOCIAL MEDIA

The U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) may review publicly available social media content in connection with certain applications. This may include applications submitted by F-1 students for benefits such as OPT, STEM OPT Extension, Economic Hardship, etc. These reviews are intended to support eligibility verification and national security screening. For more, visit USCIS.gov (https://www.uscis.gov/newsroom/news-releases/dhs-to-begin-screening-aliens-social-media-activity-for-antisemitism).

# OFF-CAMPUS EMPLOYMENT BASED ON ECONOMIC HARDSHIP FOR J-1 STUDENTS

A J-1 student may be eligible for authorization to work off-campus if “serious, urgent, and unforeseen economic circumstances” have arisen since they acquired J-1 exchange visitor status. Authorization for Severe Economic Hardship employment must be granted by an Alternate Responsible Officer (ARO) in the Office of Global Services (OGS) before any employment begins.

**Eligibility**

J-1 students may be eligible to apply for employment based on severe economic hardship if they are in valid J-1 status and off-campus employment is necessary due to a circumstance in which the economic need is serious, urgent, and unforeseen.

**Application**

For more information about economic hardship, please contact OGS to schedule an appointment with a Alternate Responsible Officer (ARO) by calling +1-617-373-2310 or visiting the front desk at 354 Richards Hall in Boston.

# F-1 SPECIAL STUDENT RELIEF (SSR)

Special Student Relief (SSR) may be available to certain F-1 students experiencing severe economic hardship due to emergent conditions (i.e. natural disasters, wars and military conflicts, national or international financial crises, or other circumstances in their country of citizenship (or in certain cases, residence)). If granted, SSR suspends certain types of restrictions on F-1 off-campus employment eligibility and may allow authorized students to reduce their course load below full-time.

- Overview of SSR (https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/students/special-student-relief)

- February 22, 2023 USCIS Policy Alert (https://www.uscis.gov/sites/default/files/document/policy-manual-updates/20230222-SpecialStudentRelief.pdf)

If you have any questions or think that you are eligible to apply for SSR, please contact OGS to request an appointment with a Designated School Official (DSO) by calling +1-617-373-2310 or stopping by the Boston campus at 354 Richards Hall.

# RELATED ARTICLES:

On Campus Employment (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/on-campus-employment/f-1-on-campus-employment/)

F-1 Curricular Practical Training (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/off-campus-employment/f-1-curricular-practical-training/)

## CONTACT OGS

354 Richards Hall
360 Huntington Avenue
Boston, MA 02115
+1-617-373-2310
OGS Service Portal (https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs)

## OFFICE HOURS

Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.-5:00p.m.
(Note: We are closed on Tuesdays from 3:00pm – 4:00pm for all staff training and meeting).
**Phone Hours:**
Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.–4:30p.m. ET

## SOCIAL

(https://www.facebook.com/NortheasternOGS/) (https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCrMAnObKFBqnSINJw

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